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TUESDAY's ELECTION - Assembly contenders face questions about their Valley roots

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California law says members of the state Legislature must live in the districts they represent. It doesn't say how long they must have lived there.

So nothing is illegal about the fact that Democrats Luz Rivas and Antonio Sanchez, leading candidates in a special election for the state Assembly on Tuesday, moved into their northeast San Fernando Valley district in December, or that Democrat Jesse Gabriel, a contender in another special election for the Assembly the same day, has lived in his West Valley district only since July.

But that hasn't stopped other candidates with deeper roots here from claiming that their prominent opponents lack the local knowledge needed to promote Valley residents' interests in Sacramento.

"Jesse moved into the district seven months ago. He doesn't know Valley issues," said Democrat Tricia Robbins Kasson, a 39-year resident

of the Valley and one of eight candidates on the ballot in Assembly District 45, where voters will fill the vacancy created when Matt Dababneh resigned following sexual-misconduct accusations.

A similar claim, about Sanchez and Rivas, was made by Democrat Patty Lopez, a 38-year Valley resident and one of six candidates running to fill the Assembly District 39 seat left open when Raul Bocanegra quit amid sexual-harassment allegations.

"I see this position being taken away by people who just moved into our district, don't know our district," Lopez said. "They feel like, 'Oh, I have money and power and I can take this seat.' "

Such rhetoric could sway some voters in the San Fernando Valley, where residents sometimes feel protective of their area, believing it receives less attention than downtown Los Angeles and West L.A. get from government leaders.

Robbins Kasson, a Tarzana resident and aide to L.A. City Councilman Bob Blumenfield, said Gabriel, who lives in Encino and is a constitutional rights attorney, shows a lack of focus on West Valley issues by sending campaign mailers that highlight his role in lawsuits against the Trump administration's plan to deport DACA recipients. Robbins Kasson's political consultant Larry Levine accused Gabriel of trying to "trick" Valley voters by saying he "attended local public schools."

"He's positioning himself as a resistance fighter against the federal government. We're running for the state Assembly representing the southwest San Fernando Valley," said Robbins Kasson, whose campaign emphasizes her work on the revitalization of Reseda and Canoga Park business districts.

Lopez, a San Fernando resident who served in the Assembly from 2014 to 2016 and is a longtime volunteer in area schools, churches and other organizations, says Rivas and Sanchez have done little to help the northeast Valley.

"Luz has been endorsed by Garcetti. Antonio is endorsed by the unions," Lopez said. "Why do you have to use those big endorsements" if you're known in the community?

But the details aren't as clear-cut as Robbins Kasson and Lopez make it sound.

Gabriel grew up in Oak Park, in Ventura County, and attended Oak Park High School, four exits west of the 45th District line along Highway 101. Gabriel said he took courses, including a constitutional law class, at Pierce College of Woodland Hills, in the district, when he was a high school senior. He, his wife and two young children lived in Santa Monica between a stint in Washington, D.C., and their move to Encino. They're members of Valley Beth Shalom in Encino.

"I think they're trying to spin it into something," Gabriel said. "I don't know how you demonstrate your connection to a community more than by saying 'We're going to put down roots here, this is where we want to raise our kids, this is where we want to spend our life.'

"With everything going on in this country and this state, and all the issues facing the Valley, if they want to talk about the fact I went to high school five miles outside the district, that's their choice," said Gabriel, who has endorsements from the Democratic Party of the San Fernando Valley and the San Fernando Valley Young Democrats.

Rivas grew up in the district in Pacoima, San Fernando and Arleta, in the 39th District, before leaving the area to earn degrees from MIT and Harvard and work in Chicago and New York. She returned to found the Pacoima-based nonprofit DIY Girls, promoting science and technology education for girls. She had a rent-control apartment in Mid-City L.A. before coming back to live in the 39th District for the first time in eight years by moving to North Hollywood in December.

"We represent different paths for people in our community," Rivas said. "I wanted to explore and I did that. I see great things about my community, and I see things I want to improve. It's because I've had different experiences and perspectives. A lot of families in our community want this for their child."

Sanchez, who was born in Chicago and moved to Mexico with his family before coming to the 39th District when he was 6, living in North Hollywood and then Pacoima. Recounting his boyhood, he mentions all the streets he walked to get to school. He said he and his wife moved to North Hollywood in December after three years outside the district.

"I know the district. I grew up in the district," Sanchez said.

Other candidates in District 39 (which includes Arleta, Lake View Terrace, Mission Hills, North Hollywood, Pacoima, Sun Valley, Sunland-Tujunga, Sylmar and San Fernando) are Democrats Yolie Anguiano and Patrea Patrick, and Republican Ricardo Benitez. Also on the ballot in District 45 (Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana, Encino and Bell Canyon) are Democrats Ankur Patel, Ray Bishop, Jeff Bornstein and Daniel Brin; Republican Justin Clark and independent Dennis Zine (who officially dropped out of the race Feb. 12).

Another special election Tuesday, in L.A.'s Assembly District 54, seeks a replacement for Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who resigned citing health problems.

In each race, if nobody receives an outright majority, the top two vote-getters will advance to a June 5 runoff. The winners will serve until Dec. 3.

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